As the summer of 1982 came to an end, I still felt cautiously optimistic about the future of the Middle East and believed we were going to be able to continue the peace process. In Beirut, the agreement worked out by Habib seemed to be succeeding: Along with troops from France and Italy, our marines had peaceably evacuated more than ten thousand PLO combatants from Beirut and were themselves preparing to leave Lebanon.

Although Begin and his cabinet had rejected the larger peace initiative, Egypt, Saudi Arabia, and Jordan appeared to be responding favorably to it. I thought there was a good chance that in time Israel, once it had evaluated the alternatives and had developed sufficient trust in it, would accept the plan, too. My goal for the remainder of the year was to continue working on Begin. I couldn’t help but believe that once the people of Israel, weary from decades of war, understood that our proposal offered the best prospect for a secure peace in the Middle East, they would support them and bring pressure on Begin’s government.

I was optimistic then, not realizing that the worst was yet to come in Lebanon.